meant to convince the bankers to invest. They demanded that accounts be first put before them and asked for strengthening the management by inducting ‘a number of leading businessmen’. Their demand to eliminate ‘all political propaganda’ was a clear signal that they wanted VOC out—having promoted and registered the company, raised substantial capital and achieved the near-impossible of acquiring two steamers, he could now be dispensed with.[2]

Their grudge against VOC was barely concealed. In K.R. Guruswami Aiyar’s backhanded compliment, VOC was ‘a zealous man but not a businessman’.[3] From the latter half of 1907, Guruswami Aiyar argued, he had ‘developed political views from which we [the directors of the company] wanted to disassociate’.[4] By early August, the police were reporting disagreements between VOC and some of the directors.[5] Though it was ostensibly about rendering of accounts of expenses relating to promotion of the company, the undercurrent was about his strident Swadeshi politics.[6] The wrangling only became worse.

In July 1907, VOC moved to Colombo with his family to focus on the actual business of the company and on the second call on the shares.[7] His absence meant that no political meetings were reported in Tuticorin.[8] But given the turmoil in the company, he was back in Tuticorin the very next month.[9] His return so soon, especially when he had moved with his family, could only mean that it was sudden and unexpected. The disagreements in the company however, did not seem to have deterred his travels to Colombo and Bombay, not to mention his other travels within the presidency.[10]

On 24 August, the directors met at Tuticorin again, with Pandithurai Thevar in the chair.[11] Following this meeting there was a change in the structure of the company. The board now doubled in strength to thirty-one directors from 15 January. C. Vijayaraghavachari, from being only a legal adviser now topped the list of directors. Four new directors joined from Tirunelveli: A. Sundara Sastri, high court vakil and public prosecutor; N.A.V. Somasundaram Pillai, high court vakil; M.D. Devadoss Pillai, high court vakil; and T.S. Subramania Pillai, district court vakil. Two were from